a 77-seat restaurant in one of the world's most competitive food cities and expect it to run to capacity meal after meal," she says. Mishra had never run a restaurant before. She had no classical culinary credentials. She also knew that as an Indian woman making Japanese food, she would face a particular kind of scrutiny. She knew about the 'impostor syndrome' around the idea. She knew there would be questions about how could someone not Japanese, and not formally trained, build authority in a cuisine so culturally specific!

Kinoya answered all these question in the most convincing way possible. Through honesty. That approach made it impossible to ignore. The restaurant quickly emerged as one of Dubai's most sought-after dining destinations, winning over both regular diners and the industry at large. In time, it became a fixture on major best-restaurant lists. Most recently, Kinoya was named the Best Restaurant in the UAE and ranked No. 2 on the MENA's 50 Best Restaurants list, a significant recognition in a region now watched closely by the global dining world.

The achievement feels especially meaningful to her because Kinoya, she explains, has never relied on hollow spectacle or drama around dishes. Its strength lies in substance. At the heart, it remains a ramen house. That is its soul and its signature. Mishra's bowls are built on years of study, but they are not presented as academic works. They are precise without being stiff. They are rooted in Japanese ingredients and technique, yet confidently personal. Her celebrated shio paitan, for instance, takes the cleaner, salt-led structure of shio ramen and gives it a fuller, more layered expression. It reflects exactly what Kinoya does best: respect tradition, understand it deeply, and then speak in its language without sounding imitative.

That clarity has helped Kinoya build fierce loyalty, something every restaurateur wants and few sustain. It is the kind of place diners return to again and again, not because it is fashionable, but because it is dependable and consistently good. Kinoya serves eight ramen varieties on the core menu and rotates additional specials to keep regular diners engaged apart from other Japanese specialities.

Mishra's story also stands out as Dubai's story because it mirrors the city at its best. Hers is not a tale of parachuting into the Emirate with a glossy concept and investor bravado. She has lived in Dubai for decades and understands its food culture. She says while Dubai maybe curious for new concepts, it is community-led and surprisingly intimate. Kinoya may now be globally known, but its rise is deeply tied to Dubai that nurtured it. She says some of the best restaurants in Dubai are homegrown.

That rise though is no longer limited to Dubai. The brand has expanded to London, opening in Harrods and taking Mishra's ramen-led vision to one of the world's most iconic retail and dining addresses. Mishra also recently launched another restaurant concept in Dubai called Tezukuri, which focusses on rice-based Japanese dishes.

Despite all the milestones, she remains protective of Kinoya's identity and wary of growing too quickly. For her, success is measured by consistency. In a city often caricatured through excess, Kinoya built itself around care, consistency and accessibility rather than theatre. Diners can drop in for a quick bowl at lunch or settle in for a much bigger meal at dinner. Mishra has resisted the idea that a celebrated restaurant must become exclusive, over-curated or overly deferential to "VIP culture." That clarity of intent has become central to Kinoya's identity.

After years of perfecting a dish that is deceptively simple yet extraordinarily complex, Mishra still views ramen the same way she did at the beginning, as a lifelong pursuit. "It's a humble dish," she says. "It takes hours to make, and it's eaten in minutes."

For diners at Kinoya, however, the impact lasts far longer. It has also shaped Mishra's place in Dubai's dining story. An Indian woman, self-taught, making Japanese food in one of the world's most competitive restaurant cities. It is a striking trajectory for someone who started out simply trying to decode a bowl of soup and noodles in her own kitchen.





